UNIT IV - GROUP COMMUNICATION

Most work in college and in jobs is done in groups. **Group communication** means exchanging ideas, information and feelings among three or more people to reach a common goal. It needs speaking, listening, cooperation and leadership.

1. Basics of Group Discussion

A **group discussion (GD)** is a structured, spoken exchange of views among a small group (usually 8 to 12 people) on a given topic. There is no winner or loser: the aim is to examine the topic from many angles and, if possible, reach a common conclusion. GDs are used in college activities, admissions and job selection because they show knowledge, communication, teamwork, leadership and attitude.

Stages of a group discussion

Stage	What happens	Useful expressions
Initiation	Someone starts with a definition, a fact, a quotation or a question on the topic. A good start shows confidence, but a rushed or poor start can hurt.	'Let me begin by defining...' / 'Statistics show that...'
Body	Members present points with reasons and examples, respond to others, agree or disagree politely, and move the discussion forward.	'I agree with Ravi that...' / 'I see it differently because...' / 'To add to that...'
Summary / conclusion	A member sums up the main points and the group's view, without adding new ideas.	'To sum up, the group felt that...'

Types of GD topics

- **Factual:** 'India's space programme.'
- **Controversial:** 'Should homework be banned?' - present balanced points.
- **Abstract:** 'Blue is better than red.'
- **Case-based:** a situation is given and the group must find a solution.

Do's and don'ts

Do	Do not
Listen carefully to others before speaking	Interrupt or speak over others
Support your points with facts and examples	Make statements without reasons
Speak clearly, politely and at a moderate speed	Shout, argue or lose your temper
Invite quiet members: 'What do you think, Meena?'	Dominate the discussion or stay completely silent
Stay on the topic; use inclusive words like 'we' and 'our view'	Go off topic or make personal remarks
Keep eye contact with all members; use positive body language	Look only at the leader or the floor
Disagree politely: 'I respect your point, but...'	Say 'You are wrong'

Sample GD: 'Social media: boon or bane?' (extract)

A: Good morning, everyone. Let me begin by saying that social media connects billions of people, but it also brings serious risks. Let us look at both sides.

B: I agree with A. On the positive side, students use it to learn, share notes and find jobs.

C: That is true. But I see the other side too: excessive use leads to addiction and waste of time.

D: To add to C's point, false news spreads quickly. We need to be careful about what we share.

A: To sum up, the group felt that social media is useful if used wisely and with limits.

2. Assigning Tasks to Class Groups

Teachers or class leaders divide the class into small groups to complete tasks together. Good task assignment makes the work fair and effective.

- **Form groups of 4 to 6.** Mix students with different strengths.
- **Give a clear task:** state the topic, the output (report, chart, presentation, role play) and the deadline.
- **Set rules and time limits.**
- **Assign roles inside the group:** leader (guides), speaker (presents), note-taker (records), timekeeper (watches the time) and researcher (finds information).
- **Rotate roles** in later tasks so that everyone practises every skill.
- **Check progress** and give feedback.

Role	Responsibility
Leader	Guides the discussion, keeps the group on task, ensures every member speaks
Speaker / spokesperson	Presents the group's result to the class
Note-taker / recorder	Writes down ideas and decisions
Timekeeper	Makes sure each step finishes on time
Researcher	Collects facts and references

3. Appointing Group Leaders to Communicate

A **group leader** represents the group and makes sure communication flows within the group and between the group and the teacher or class.

Qualities of a good group leader

- Good communicator and listener.
- Fair and unbiased; treats all members with respect.
- Calm in problems; able to solve conflicts.
- Motivates others and shares credit.
- Organised and responsible; keeps the group on time.

How leaders can be appointed

- The teacher nominates a leader, or the group chooses one by agreement or vote.
- Leadership may rotate so that each member gets a chance.

What the leader does in communication

- Explains the task to all members in clear words and checks understanding.
- Invites ideas from everyone and summarises discussions.
- Reports progress and problems to the teacher.
- Presents or chooses a spokesperson for the final presentation.

4. Completion of Tasks Based on Communication

A group completes its task successfully only when its members communicate well. Communication connects planning, action and feedback.

Step	Communication needed
1. Understand the task	Ask questions and clear doubts; repeat the task in your own words
2. Plan	Brainstorm ideas; discuss and agree on a plan and timeline
3. Divide the work	Match jobs to members' strengths; state who does what by when
4. Carry out the work	Share updates regularly; ask for help when stuck
5. Combine the results	Review each part together; remove repetitions and gaps
6. Present and evaluate	Give and receive feedback; learn for the next task

Barriers: unclear instructions, unequal participation, ego clashes, and lack of listening. **Solutions:** regular meetings, clear roles, written notes of decisions and respectful discussion.

5. Group Cohesion Through Communication

Group cohesion is the feeling of unity, trust and commitment that holds a group together. A cohesive group works better, enjoys the work and handles conflict well. Communication builds cohesion in these ways:

- **Openness and honesty:** members share ideas and worries without fear.
- **Active listening:** every member feels heard and valued.
- **Shared goals:** everyone knows and agrees on the purpose of the group.
- **Appreciation:** recognise each member's contribution: 'That was a great idea, Meena.'
- **Constructive feedback:** criticise the idea, not the person.
- **Conflict resolution:** discuss disagreements calmly and look for a solution that works for everyone.
- **Team activities and informal talk** also strengthen bonds.

When communication is poor, misunderstandings, rumours, conflicts and low motivation follow, and the group may fall apart.

6. Group Presentations

In a group presentation, several members present one topic together. It tests both individual speaking and teamwork.

Steps

- **Choose and understand the topic;** decide the key message.
- **Research and divide** the topic into parts; each member takes one part.
- **Structure:** Introduction (topic and outline) - Main body (the parts in a logical order) - Conclusion (summary and final message) - Question and answer.
- **Prepare visuals** together so that the slides look consistent.
- **Rehearse** as a group to fix the timing and the transitions.
- **Deliver:** speak clearly, face the audience, support each other and hand over smoothly: 'Now my colleague Meena will explain...'
- **Handle questions** as a team: the right person answers, and others add when needed.

Tips

- Dress neatly and be on time.
- Do not read from the slides or notes; use keywords.
- Every member should speak for roughly equal time.
- Thank the audience at the end.

7. Use of PowerPoint Presentations

PowerPoint is presentation software used to make slides with text, pictures, charts and videos. Slides support the speaker; they are not a script.

Principles of good slides

Principle	How to apply it
One idea per slide	Keep a clear heading and 3 to 5 short points
Brief text	Use keywords and short phrases, not long sentences or paragraphs
Readable fonts	Body text at least 24 point; headings 32 point or larger; plain fonts such as Arial or Calibri
High contrast	Dark text on a light background, or light text on a dark one
Visuals	Use relevant pictures, charts and diagrams; avoid cluttered or low-quality images
Consistent design	Same fonts, colours and layout throughout
Limited effects	Use animation and sound only where it helps

Structure of a slide deck

- **Title slide:** topic, names and date.
- **Outline / agenda:** what will be covered.
- **Content slides:** main points with examples and visuals.
- **Conclusion slide:** key takeaways.
- **Thank-you / Questions slide.**

During the presentation

- Speak to the audience, not to the screen.
- Use the slide as a cue and explain more than what is written.
- Use a pointer or gesture to guide attention.
- Check your equipment and file format before the presentation, and keep a backup copy.